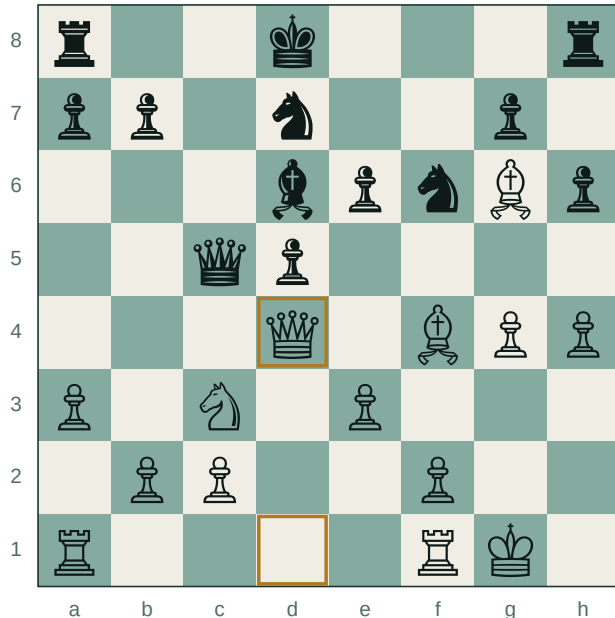


Capture the defender: Black, move 15

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 15.Qxd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

15...Qxd4 16. exd4 Bxf4

15...Qxd4 The queen captures the queen on d4. From d4 it attacks knight on c3 and bishop on f4. Recorded reply: **16.exd4**.

16...Bxf4 The bishop captures the bishop on f4.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on g6. Check for tactical protection.